How to Help Your Husband Die

By David James Poissant

INTRODUCTION

Someone is taking their last breath in a hospital bed today, and you're frustrated sitting in traffic. Someone is spending their first night alone after years of love, and you're upset that your partner left dishes in the sink. Someone is burying their mother, and you're annoyed your mom called you twice today. Perspective is everything. Appreciate the little things because, one day, they'll be the big things.

How to Help Your Husband Die by David James Poissant . . . in which a terrible loss punctuates the unfathomable depths of grief.

The morning your husband, the chef, stays in bed, bleary-eyed, sweating, and says for the past six months he's been coughing up blood, turn hysterical. Demand he drive you both to the emergency room at once.

Ask why he didn't see a doctor six months ago. Ask why he's such a *man* when it comes to his health. Ask what he thought would happen if he kept smoking. If you scold and scold, when the bad news comes, it won't be your fault. When the bad news comes, you can say, *I told you so*.

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When the bad news comes, cry . . . He will not cry. He will not say anything at all. You will ride home in silence.

Tell him not to worry, that it could be a thousand things, that the hospital only said *possibly,* that no good doctor diagnoses something like *that* on a first visit. At home, when you think of the way you spoke to him that morning, run to the toilet and throw up. When he asks what made you sick, blame the week-old pizza you reheated for lunch. Blame anything but him.

Get second opinions, thirds, however many it takes to find a doctor who will say, *This is not what it looks like.*

Learn tricks to keep yourself from crying. When a doctor talks, cross your arms. When the doctor leaves the room, press your thumbs to your eyes and suck in air. Before your husband can ask, say, *I'm okay* . . .

Wait. By the time this is all over, you will know patience in a whole new way. Wait for the nurses. Wait for the doctors. Keep track of time. On average, find you spend five to six hours a week sitting in rooms waiting for people to see you. Wait. Learn new ways to wait. Bring books. Bring bills. Bring board games. In waiting rooms and offices, play cards. Hearts, Spades, Crazy Eights. Quit Slapjack after you

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miss the pile and leave a bruise on his hand that lingers for weeks . . .

After a month of meetings, tell yourself that you are tired of doctors, that tomorrow's X-rays will be the last. Smile when you imagine the wait is almost over. The doctor will tell your husband that he has several options, but only one, really, if he wants to live. Listen and smile -- smile the way you do at a person you wish would just, for God's sake, please stop talking.

What the doctor won't tell you is that the disease will tear your husband apart. That he will be sicker than he has ever been. That, in the end, it will be the cure that kills him. But you will, somehow, in the flicker of an instant, see what lies ahead. Your husband won't see another summer.

He will begin treatments in a week. Beg him to quit his job. He will say he's not giving up that easy. Yes, he knows your health insurance could cover him. Yes, he knows he needs rest, that the kitchen of a four-star restaurant is no place for a chemo patient. No, he won't quit his job. Quit your job. You never liked it anyway. Who grows up saying, *I want to be a dental hygienist*? Kids want to be artists, veterinarians, firefighters.

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When you find you have too much time on your hands, decide to learn everything there is to know about cancer. Decide you want to know exactly how your husband is going to die. The moment you do, believe that you can save him.

Study the disease. Go to the university library. Read every book they own on cancer. Search for the card catalog. Learn the Dewey decimal system. If you learn enough about the cancer, you can conquer it. If you search long enough—comb every essay, read every study, explore each article—you will find a treatment.

Make this your day job, five days a week. To battle fatigue, work harder. Don't stop. Stay at the library all day, every day. Don't leave until your fingertips are gray with ink, until your tailbone aches from the curve of the library's stylishly modern chairs. When you can't take any more, are ready to give up, you will know guilt . . .

By winter, you will know more than the doctors. Recommend treatments. Question their methods. Grow irritated when a doctor hasn't heard of a specific drug or experiment in Southeast Asia.

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When your husband comes home from the restaurant one night and falls to the floor, understand it's time for him to stay home. Forget the library. Concentrate on chemotherapy. Concentrate on radiation. Concentrate on making it through each day.

Notice the hair in the bathroom. Strands in the sink and shower, tangles in drains. When you find clumps in the bed, collect the hair. Save it in a Ziploc bag like a child's first haircut keepsake. When he finds the bag and yells at you, throw it out. Once he's lost the last of his hair, tell him that he is beautiful. Wait until he's asleep to sob.

Try church. When the priest places the wafer on your tongue and says, "This is His body, broken for you," think, *This is* his *body*. Spend the rest of the day whispering it to yourself: *This is his body. This is his body*. . .

There are certain things you should know.

There will be things you can't make better. Don't try to hold his hand when he coughs. Don't try to trade *Seinfeld* reruns for hours of meaningful this-is-your-life conversation. (He'll want nothing to do with such talk.)

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Know that no matter how many laps you walk to raise money for research, no matter how many free T-shirts you earn, your husband is still going to die . . .

The night he has the first seizure, call 911. Ride in the ambulance. Bury your face in your husband's shirt and cry. Sit beside him on the thin hospital mattress. Watch him sleep. Stay awake, all night, running your hand down his arm. Realize you spent so much time studying the disease that you forgot to prepare for what comes next.

From this point forward, spend your days in the hospital room, for this is where he is meant to spend the rest of his life. Learn to tell when he wants to talk about this and when he doesn't, regardless of the words that come out of his mouth. Buy a potted plant. Place the plant on a table by the window, where it will get plenty of light. Water it every day. Tell yourself that as long as the plant lives, he will live. On his worst days, imagine the plant as his lifeline. *The plant is alive. He cannot die.*

Get used to seeing blood drawn from his body. Eventually, he won't notice the needles. At night, trace the veins of his arms. Rub the purple circles left by needles jabbed too hard. Hold your breath and kiss each bruise.

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Be brave.

While he's still lucid, write the will, then put it away in the safety deposit box with the marriage license and birth certificates. Marvel at how these three—birth, death, and the union that came between—fit into an inch-deep metal drawer.

At the hospital, read books to him, as many as you can. Don't talk doctors or painkillers or funeral arrangements. Don't make him leaf through brochures to pick out a casket, flowers, the perfect burial plot. There is no last lesson, no big picture, no final words. So, read to him and let his mind wander. Read even when you know he's not listening . . .

When the very end is in sight, tell him you're leaving and you're taking him with you. Clean him and dress him and pull out his IV. Let the fluid flow from the tube to the floor. Unplug the heart monitor, and pull the black pads from his chest. He'll worry about expenses, about insurance coverage. He'll worry about *being a burden*. Tell him he never could be.

When you lift him, his lightness will make you dizzy. He will feel like a child in your arms. Help him into a

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wheelchair, then make a break for it. Wheel him out a side door, and, when you hear a woman's voice, don't look back. Drive home and put him in his *real* bed.

Understand that things will move quickly now, without fluids and pills, monitors and morphine, electrodes and tubes. Bring him more covers when he grows cold.

While he sleeps, listen to him breathe. Lie awake counting breaths. As the breaths grow farther apart, wonder, in the silence of daybreak, whether each breath you just heard was the last. Do this, and you will know despair. You will know helplessness. Fall asleep with the sunrise, weak, feeling alone . . .

Wake to his smile beside you, and see he's been watching you sleep. He'll be too tired to talk. Don't try to fill up the silence with words. Help him out of bed with quick, simple commands. *Lift your head. Help me with your feet. Hold my shoulder.* Otherwise, keep quiet. Nothing you say can make this sacred. Everything you want to tell him before he dies is only for you, so pray it to yourself tonight when he's gone.

Take him to the beach. Take him because it is beautiful. Take him because you can. Sit on the shore and trace your

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initials together in the sand. Play tic-tac-toe and let him win. Hold him as he coughs and coughs and coughs. He will rattle like a skeleton in your arms.

When your husband tells you every terrible thing he's done, every way he's wronged you, no matter how it hurts, don't make him beg your forgiveness. Tell him you love him, that nothing else matters. Do this because you've reached the end together, because why make it harder. Love him.

The whole round world will funnel into nothingness, and you will see the truth in his eyes: that life, that *living,* is more than what's come before. That all you have is this moment. Don't look away or he'll disappear. The world is here only as long as you keep your eyes open. Keep your eyes on him and he'll never leave you, if you can just keep from blinking. And your eyes will ache, they'll burn from holding them open for so long, and when you blink, like that, he'll be gone.

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